

First Hong Kong Linguistics Olympiad
24 March 2019
Individual Contest Problems

Rules for writing out the solutions

Do not copy the statements of the problems. Write down your solution to each problem on the answer booklet. Your answers must be well-supported by argument. Even a perfectly correct answer will be given a low score unless accompanied by an explanation.

Problem 1 (15 points). Taiwanese Southern-Min 1x15+bonus6+bouns3=24

(1) (1x15)

1. aluminum
2. ammonia
3. aspirin
4. ice cream
5. out
6. karaoke
7. camera
8. catalogue
9. curtain
10. kilo
11. cup
12. concrete
13. cholera
14. commission
15. coat

(2) (6pt)

1. All syllables are assigned tones;
2. Syllable can only have the structure of 1) vowel; 2) consonant+vowel; 3) consonant+vowel+consonant and without consonant cluster;
3. English syllable word final consonants can only be kept when it is non-labial nasal (i.e. -n, -ng), otherwise it will either be 1) pronounced with a vowel added or 2) dropped;
4. All the retroflex sound /r/ is pronounced as /l/, for example, camera ['kæm(ə)rə] - [kha me lah];
5. No diphthong in the loan words – it will be replaced by a long vowel, e.g. kilo [ki:ləu] - /əu/ is pronounced as /oo/; coat [kəut] - /oo/;
6. No shwa /ə/ in loan words – replaced by /e/ or /a/, e.g. cholera ['kɒləɾə] – [kohh le lah];
7. All open (i.e. not ending in consonant) and nasal ending syllables have full (long) duration, others (ending in -p, -t, -k, -h) have short/abrupt/abbreviated tones;
8. All the segments (vowels and consonants) can be mapped back to original English segment, but not the ending consonant in with abrupt tones (e.g. -p, -t, -k, -h) as some of them are added without corresponding sounds in English.

(3) (3pt)

These abrupt syllables are special phonological characteristics of Taiwanese Min-nan as some of them do not exist in their loan source. They normally end with voiceless consonants /h/ /k/ and /p/ (as shown in /tsiap₅/ /sap₅/ in the examples).

[The following part of answer is NOT required as it does take some learned linguistic knowledge and cannot be derived from the data alone] These abrupt tones are what is called ‘entering tone’ 入聲 in Chinese. They are words with short duration ending with unreleased consonants, i.e. the consonants are not pronounced fully, only the initial part of it is pronounced, resulting in the syllable being perceived as cutting short, ending abruptly. Hence these are all voiceless consonants and -h in fact stands for glottal stop.